BOARDING HOUSE TYCOON

GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT | MVP



Environment concept illustration. Visual reference only; not final production art.

Build • Manage • Grow Your Boarding House

Version 2.0 | 7 November 2026 | Design baseline for prototype and MVP

DOCUMENT STATUS

Core design decisions and starting balance values are locked as the first implementation baseline. Numeric balance values remain tunable after playtesting.

Working title: Boarding House Tycoon (English title for the project formerly described as “Tập làm chủ trọ”).

Document Guide

This document defines the MVP experience, gameplay rules, economy, progression, content scope, and implementation-facing acceptance criteria. It replaces the earlier high-level concept outline with a consistent, testable design baseline.

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How to Read This Document

- Locked design rules: implement as written for the first prototype unless a blocker is discovered.
- Balance parameters: use the supplied values as the initial tuning baseline; change them only when playtest evidence supports a change.
- Concept images: AI-generated visual explorations included to communicate tone and layout. They are not approved final assets or authoritative UI copy.

IMPORTANT DESIGN GUARDRAIL

This is a casual idle tycoon, not a detailed landlord simulator. Do not add life simulation, accounting, relationship, or staff-management systems to the MVP.

1. Product Overview & Design Pillars

1.1 Product Snapshot

Field	Decision
Working title	Boarding House Tycoon
Genre	Casual Idle Tycoon / Lightweight Management
Platform	Mobile-first; iOS and Android
Orientation	Portrait, 9:16
Camera / presentation	2D isometric or 2.5D cartoon environment
Game mode	Single-player with offline progression
Target session	Approximately 2–5 minutes for a normal check-in
Core fantasy	Start with a small Vietnamese boarding house and grow it into a thriving rental property.
MVP property size	One boarding-house property, expandable to six rentable rooms

1.2 Product Promise

The player starts with a modest boarding house, earns rent from occupied rooms, accepts suitable tenants, handles occasional situations, and reinvests income into new rooms and upgrades. Growth must be visible in both the economy and the environment.

1.3 Design Pillars

Pillar	Player-facing promise	Design implication
Visible Growth	The property visibly improves over time.	New rooms and room upgrades change the main isometric scene.
Meaningful Investment	The player chooses between expanding capacity and improving income per room.	Build and upgrade options have different costs, benefits, and payback periods.
Lightweight Management	Tenants and events create variety without becoming chores.	No deep schedules, needs meters, or constant maintenance tasks.
Idle Progression	The property continues earning while the player is away.	Occupied rooms accrue income offline, with an eight-hour cap.

1.4 Explicit Non-Pillars

- The MVP is not a realistic rental-business simulator.
- The MVP does not simulate tenant hunger, sleep, work schedules, relationships, or daily movement.
- The MVP does not require frequent logins to prevent property deterioration.
- The MVP does not rely on multiple currencies, energy systems, or mandatory monetization.

2. Core Gameplay Loop & Session Design

2.1 Core Loop

Step	Player activity	Game response
1. Earn	Open the game and review accumulated rent.	Occupied rooms generate passive income automatically.

Step	Player activity	Game response
2. Manage	Review vacant rooms, candidates, and active events.	The player accepts tenants and resolves optional situations.
3. Invest	Choose a room to build or upgrade.	Cash is spent and the property changes visually.
4. Grow	Increase occupancy and room quality.	Net income rises and the player approaches the next milestone.
5. Unlock	Reach occupancy and upgrade requirements.	Room capacity and higher room levels become available.

LOOP RULE

Missions and events support the loop; they are not mandatory steps in every session. A player may simply collect income, make one investment, and leave.

2.2 Typical Short Session (2–5 Minutes)

1. Review Cash, income rate, and the current Main Mission.
2. Inspect new tenant candidates and assign a suitable candidate to an empty room.
3. Resolve one active event if one is waiting.
4. Compare build and upgrade options, then make an investment if affordable.
5. See the property update and the next milestone or mission progress.

2.3 Long-Term Motivation

- Increase the number of occupied rooms and the total net income rate.
- Improve basic rooms into improved and premium rooms.
- Unlock higher room capacity and new tenant/event content.
- Complete the MVP progression by developing the property to six rooms.

2.4 Player Agency

The player chooses when to invest, which room to upgrade, which candidates to accept, and how to respond to events. The game should explain costs and consequences before confirmation. Avoid hidden penalties.

3. Economy & Balance Baseline

ECONOMY DECISION — LOCKED FOR MVP

One currency (Cash), automatic rent accrual, one game day equal to one real hour, 10% operating cost on gross rent, and offline accumulation capped at eight hours.

3.1 Currency

Cash is the only MVP currency. It is used for room construction, room upgrades, and event choices. Do not introduce premium currency, energy, materials, or separate upgrade tokens in the MVP.

3.2 Time Scale & Rent Accrual

Rule	Baseline
Game time scale	1 Game Day = 1 real-time hour.
Rent accrual	Continuous and proportional to elapsed game time; the displayed Cash balance updates automatically.
Per-minute rate	A room earns Rent per Game Day ÷ 60 each real minute while occupied.

Rule	Baseline
Operating cost	10% of gross rent, deducted proportionally.
Net income	90% of gross rent for occupied rooms.
Vacant room	Produces zero rent and zero room-specific operating cost.
Displayed values	Show whole Cash values; retain fractional accrual internally to prevent rounding loss.

3.3 Room Rent & Net Income

Room level	Gross rent / Game Day	Operating cost (10%)	Net income / Game Day
Level 1	120	12	108
Level 2	210	21	189
Level 3	350	35	315

Because one Game Day equals one real hour, the Net Income / Game Day column is also the net income rate per real-time hour for a continuously occupied room.

3.4 Core Economy Formulas

FORMULAS

GrossIncomePerGameDay = Sum(RoomRent for all occupied rooms)
OperatingCost = GrossIncomePerGameDay × 10%
NetIncomePerGameDay = GrossIncomePerGameDay × 90%
CashAccrued = NetIncomePerGameDay × ElapsedRealHours

3.5 Construction & Upgrade Costs

Action	Cost (Cash)	Effect
Build Room 3	900	Adds a new Level 1 room.
Build Room 4	1,400	Adds a new Level 1 room.
Build Room 5	2,100	Adds a new Level 1 room.
Build Room 6	3,000	Adds a new Level 1 room.
Upgrade Level 1 → Level 2	650	Rent increases from 120 to 210 per Game Day.
Upgrade Level 2 → Level 3	1,300	Rent increases from 210 to 350 per Game Day.

Capacity expansion unlocks room slots; it does not have a separate Cash price. The player pays only when constructing each individual room.

3.6 Starting Economy

Starting item	Value
Starting Cash	1,000
Initial room slots	2
Initial rooms	2 × Level 1
Initial occupancy	1 occupied / 1 vacant
Initial tenant	1 Office Worker in a Level 1 room
Initial candidate	1 Student candidate

Starting item	Value
Initial capacity	2 rooms

ONBOARDING CONSISTENCY

The starting Office Worker can afford a Level 2 room (budget 380), so the first upgrade mission is immediately valid. The initial Student candidate can rent the vacant Level 1 room (rent 120, budget 150).

3.7 Investment Payback

Investment	Cost	Increase in net income	Approx. payback
Build Room 3 (Level 1)	900	108 / Game Day	8.3 Game Days
Build Room 4 (Level 1)	1,400	108 / Game Day	13.0 Game Days
Build Room 5 (Level 1)	2,100	108 / Game Day	19.4 Game Days
Build Room 6 (Level 1)	3,000	108 / Game Day	27.8 Game Days
Upgrade Level 1 → Level 2	650	81 / Game Day	8.0 Game Days
Upgrade Level 2 → Level 3	1,300	126 / Game Day	10.3 Game Days

Payback assumes the new room is occupied continuously, ignores events and temporary modifiers, and uses the listed room-number build cost. Later room slots intentionally have higher costs to prevent one offline collection from skipping the entire expansion curve.

3.8 Economy Guardrails

- Never charge operating cost for a vacant room.
- Do not allow passive operating costs to push Cash below zero; the 10% deduction is applied to rent earned.
- Show the next room cost, rent, net income, and estimated payback before the player confirms an investment.
- Do not silently change rent after an upgrade or tenant assignment.

4. Building & Room Upgrade System

4.1 Property Structure

The MVP contains one boarding-house property with a maximum of six rentable rooms. Capacity grows through two milestones. A new room is created instantly after payment and starts at Level 1.

Stage	Unlock condition	Room capacity	Unlocks
Start	Default	2	Core room and tenant loop.
Expansion 1	2 occupied rooms	4	Level 2 room upgrades and two additional build slots.
Expansion 2	4 occupied rooms AND at least 2 Level 2 rooms	6	Level 3 room upgrades and two additional build slots.

4.2 Room Levels

Level	Description	Rent / Game Day	Eligible tenants
Level 1 — Basic	Simple furniture and essential facilities.	120	Student, Office Worker, Messy Tenant
Level 2 — Improved	Cleaner, better furnished, more comfortable.	210	Office Worker
Level 3 — Premium	Air conditioning and premium furniture/decor.	350	Office Worker



Illustrative room-upgrade progression (basic → improved → premium). AI concept reference; final art must be produced consistently.

4.3 Upgrade Rules

- A room can be upgraded only when the next level is unlocked.
- An occupied room can be upgraded only if its current tenant budget is at least the new room rent. This prevents an upgrade from making the current tenant unaffordable.
- Vacant rooms can be upgraded at any time after the relevant level unlocks.
- Upgrade applies instantly after Cash is deducted.
- Every level must produce a visible environment change on the main property view.

4.4 Visual Upgrade Checklist

Level	Minimum visible changes
Level 1	Basic bed, minimal storage, simple lighting, limited decoration.
Level 2	Improved bed, wardrobe or storage, table, cleaner surfaces, plant or wall decor.
Level 3	Air conditioner, premium furniture, better lighting, rug or upgraded decor.

4.5 Build Rules

- Build buttons are enabled only when an unlocked room slot is available and the player has enough Cash.
- All new rooms start at Level 1.
- Building a room does not automatically assign a tenant.
- Construction and upgrades do not require timers in the MVP.

5. Tenant System

Tenants are lightweight archetypes that provide affordability constraints and event eligibility. They are not full life-simulation agents.

5.1 MVP Tenant Archetypes

Archetype	Maximum budget	Preferred room	Gameplay role
Student	150 Cash / Game Day	Level 1	Budget-sensitive tenant; suitable for basic rooms.
Office Worker	380 Cash / Game Day	Level 2–3	Stable higher-budget tenant; can afford all room levels.
Messy Tenant	180 Cash / Game Day	Level 1	Can make hallway/cleanliness events more likely.



Character-style exploration. The image communicates a friendly cartoon direction; archetype identity and final character designs are not approved by this reference.

5.2 Affordability & Room Matching

- A candidate is eligible for a room when Maximum Budget ≥ Room Rent.
- Preferred Room Level is a preference, not an absolute restriction. An Office Worker may rent a Level 1 room if no higher-level room is available.
- Students and Messy Tenants can rent Level 1 only under the current rent values.
- The player selects which compatible vacant room to assign; the game must not auto-assign tenants.

5.3 Candidate Generation

Rule	Baseline
Generation interval	One candidate check every 5 minutes of active online play.
Eligibility	Generate only when at least one vacant room can be afforded by an archetype.
Queue limit	Maximum 3 candidates waiting.
Candidate weights	Student 50%, Office Worker 30%, Messy Tenant 20% among eligible archetypes; re-normalize weights when some archetypes are ineligible.
Persistence	Candidates remain in the queue while the player is offline; no expiration in MVP.
Player action	Accept and assign to a compatible vacant room, or reject.

5.4 Room & Tenant Lifecycle

State	Meaning	Transition
Candidate	An applicant is available in the queue.	Player accepts or rejects.
Occupied	Tenant has been assigned to a room and generates rent.	Tenant remains assigned for the MVP; no automatic departure timer.
Vacant	Room has no tenant.	A suitable candidate can be assigned.

MVP SIMPLIFICATION

Tenants do not leave automatically because of a timer. The MVP has no tenant-removal action, lease expiry, satisfaction meter, payment reliability meter, relationship score, or daily schedule. Room churn is intentionally deferred.

5.5 Initial State

- One Office Worker occupies the first Level 1 room.
- One Student candidate is waiting for the second Level 1 room.
- Accepting the Student completes Main Mission 1 and unlocks Expansion 1 after the second room becomes occupied.

6. Event System

Events create occasional decisions and local humor. They should not punish players for being offline or interrupt the core investment loop too often.

6.1 Event Categories

Category	Purpose	Examples
Financial	Create a Cash-versus-income decision.	Shared utility outage.
Daily Life	Reflect familiar boarding-house situations.	Blocked hallway, noise complaint.
Facility	Create a repair-versus-delay decision.	Broken shared water tap.
Opportunity	Offer a short-term growth opportunity.	A group of students wants two rooms.

6.2 Global Event Rules

Rule	Baseline
Online only	New events may trigger only while the game is active.
Check interval	Run one event check every 5 minutes of active online time.
Base chance	25% per valid check when at least one event is eligible.
Active event limit	Maximum one unresolved event at a time.
Global cooldown	At least 10 minutes of active online time after an event is resolved.
Frequency cap	Maximum 3 triggered events in any rolling 60-minute online window.
Per-event cooldown	The same event template cannot trigger again for 30 minutes of active online time.
Selection weights	Eligible events are selected uniformly by default. If a Messy Tenant is present, Hallway Clutter receives a 2× selection weight.
Eligibility	Only select event templates whose conditions are currently satisfied.

Rule	Baseline
Pending event	An unresolved event persists when the app closes and is shown again on return.
Outcome	Choices have deterministic, clearly displayed results. Randomness selects the event, not the result.
Effect duration	Temporary income modifiers use Game Time and continue while offline; event/candidate spawn cooldowns use active online time only.
Modifier stacking	Building-wide income reductions stack additively and are capped at 25% total reduction.

6.3 Event Selection Logic

1. Every 5 minutes of active online time, check that no event is active, the global cooldown has elapsed, and the rolling-hour cap has room.
2. Build the eligible event pool using current rooms, tenants, Cash, and event-specific cooldowns; if it is empty, skip this check.
3. Roll the 25% base chance. If the roll fails, show no event.
4. If the roll succeeds, select one event from the eligible pool using the configured selection weights.
5. Display the event and its exact choice costs/effects. Keep it pending until the player chooses.
6. Apply the deterministic outcome, save state, and start global and event-specific cooldowns.

6.4 MVP Event Catalogue

Event	Category / trigger	Choice A	Choice B
Shared utility outage	Financial. Requires at least 2 occupied rooms.	Pay 120 Cash now to restore full service; no income modifier.	Wait 1 Game Day: all occupied rooms earn 10% less gross rent during the outage; no Cash is deducted.
Hallway clutter	Daily Life. Requires at least 1 occupied room; Messy Tenant increases eligibility weight.	Warn the tenant for free; clear the current issue.	Hire a cleaner for 100 Cash; clear the issue and suppress this event for 60 online minutes.
Broken shared water tap	Facility. Requires at least 1 occupied room.	Repair immediately for 150 Cash; no rent penalty.	Delay repair for 1 Game Day; gross rent from all occupied rooms is reduced by 15% during that period, then the issue clears and normal rent resumes.
Noise complaint	Daily Life. Requires at least 1 occupied room.	Warn the tenant for free; same-tenant noise event cooldown applies.	Hire a mediator for 80 Cash; suppress noise events for that tenant for 60 online minutes.
Group of students wants two rooms	Opportunity. Requires 2 vacant Level 1 rooms.	Accept: fill two suitable vacant Level 1 rooms with Student tenants.	Decline: no cost and no penalty.

6.5 Event UX Requirements

- Show the event category, affected room/tenant if applicable, and short context.
- Show exact Cash cost or income modifier before the player chooses.
- Disable unaffordable Cash options instead of allowing negative Cash.
- Temporary event income modifiers are applied to gross rent first; the 10% operating-cost deduction is then calculated on the modified gross rent.
- After resolving an event, summarize the outcome in one short confirmation.
- Do not spawn multiple event popups at once.

7. Mission & Progression System

The MVP uses a single Main Mission chain to teach the loop and guide progression. Daily Missions are deferred until core retention and session patterns are validated.

7.1 Main Mission Sequence

#	Objective	Reward (Cash)	Prerequisite / note
1	Accept the second tenant.	100	Initial Student candidate is available.
2	Upgrade one room to Level 2.	150	Upgrade the occupied Office Worker room or a compatible vacant room.
3	Build the third room.	200	Expansion 1 must be unlocked.
4	Have 3 occupied rooms.	150	Three rooms must be occupied at the same time.
5	Have 4 occupied rooms.	250	Room 4 must be built and occupied.
6	Have 2 rooms at Level 2.	300	Both upgraded rooms must be budget-compatible with their tenants.
7	Upgrade one room to Level 3.	400	Expansion 2 unlocks Level 3.

7.2 Progression Milestones

Stage	Condition	Unlock
Start	New game.	2 room slots, Level 1, basic tenant pool.
Milestone 1	2 occupied rooms.	Capacity increases to 4; Level 2 becomes available.
Milestone 2	4 occupied rooms AND at least 2 Level 2 rooms.	Capacity increases to 6; Level 3 becomes available.
MVP completion	Player can develop all 6 rooms and complete the 7-step Main Mission chain.	Core MVP progression demonstrated.

7.3 Mission Rules

- Only one Main Mission is active at a time.
- Mission progress is tracked automatically from player actions and current state.
- Rewards are credited directly to Cash after completion.
- A mission must never require a feature that has not yet been unlocked.
- Mission completion and reward claiming must be saved immediately.

7.4 Deferred Mission Features

- Daily Missions and streak rewards are out of scope for the MVP.
- Event-specific missions are out of scope; events may contribute to future mission types after the core system is validated.

8. Time, Offline Income & Save Data

8.1 Offline Income Rules

Rule	Baseline
Offline cap	8 hours maximum per offline interval.
Income source	Occupied rooms only.
Rate	Same net rent rate as online play.
Events	No new events trigger while offline.
Candidates	No new candidates are generated while offline; existing candidates persist.
Tenant status	Existing tenants retain their room assignment.

Rule	Baseline
Cooldowns	Event and candidate spawn timers advance only during active online time.
Temporary modifiers	Use Game Time and continue to elapse offline; combined building-wide income reduction is capped at 25%.
Repeated calculation	The same offline interval must never be credited twice.

8.2 Offline Formula

OFFLINE CALCULATION

OfflineHours = min(max(CurrentTimestamp − LastActiveTimestamp, 0), 8)
OfflineGameDays = OfflineHours (because 1 Game Day = 1 real hour)
OfflineGross = Sum(OccupiedRoomRentPerGameDay) × OfflineGameDays
OfflineNet = OfflineGross × 90%

When temporary modifiers are active, integrate occupied-room gross rent over the offline interval using the active gross-rent multiplier; then apply the 90% net factor. Building-wide reductions stack additively and are capped at 25%.

8.3 Worked Example

Assume the property has three occupied rooms: one Level 1, one Level 2, and one Level 3.

Room	Gross rent / Game Day
Level 1	120
Level 2	210
Level 3	350
Total gross	680
Operating cost (10%)	68
Net per Game Day / real hour	612
Net for 8 offline hours	4,896

8.4 Save Data Requirements

Data group	Required fields
Player	Cash, lifetime gross income, lifetime net income (optional analytics).
Building	Room capacity, unlocked room levels, property milestone flags.
Room	Room ID, room level, tenant ID or vacant state.
Tenant	Tenant ID, archetype, maximum budget, room assignment, temporary status/effects.
Candidates	Candidate queue, archetype, creation time, maximum queue count.
Events	Active event ID, affected entity, choice state, event cooldown timestamps, recent event history, and temporary income modifiers with start/end timestamps.
Missions	Current mission ID, progress, completed mission IDs, reward-granted flag.
Time	Last active timestamp, last offline calculation timestamp, fractional income remainder.
Meta	Save schema version for future migrations.

8.5 Save & Load Rules

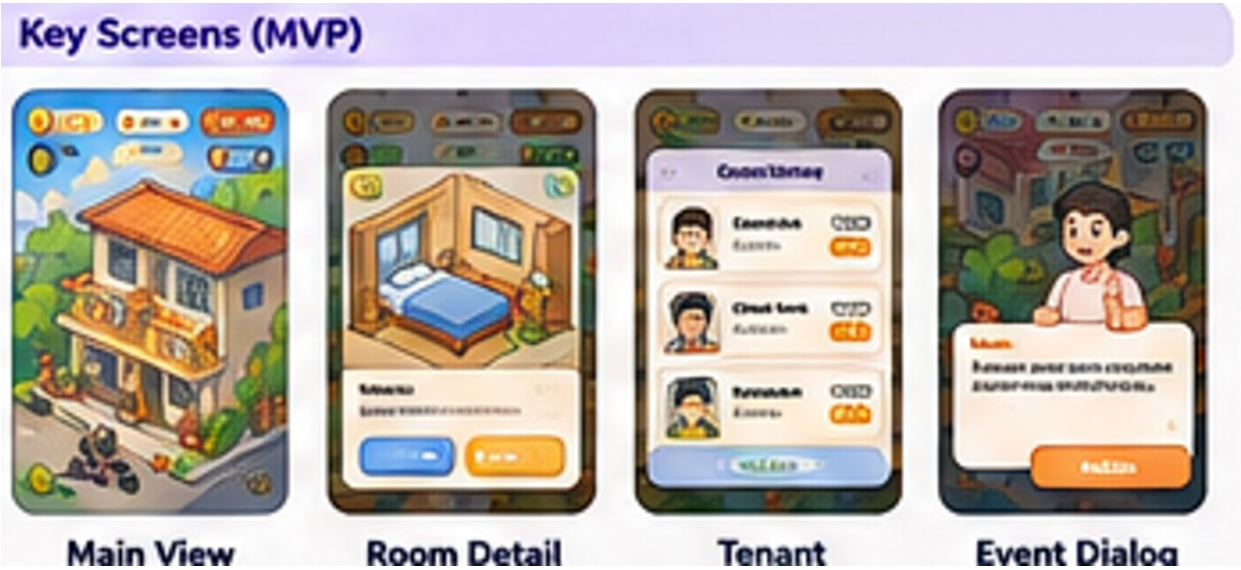
- Autosave after every meaningful state change: build, upgrade, tenant acceptance/rejection, event outcome, mission reward, and milestone unlock.
- Also autosave at least once every 60 seconds while active.
- On resume, calculate offline income once, apply it, update the offline checkpoint, and persist the result atomically.
- If the device clock is earlier than the saved timestamp, treat offline duration as zero.
- Clamp offline duration to eight hours even if the app was closed longer.
- Temporary event income modifiers continue to elapse offline because they use Game Time. Offline income must integrate the modifier only over the portion of the offline interval in which it is active.
- Local save is sufficient for MVP; cloud sync and cross-device progression are deferred.

9. UI/UX Requirements

The main property view is the primary play space. Important actions should be reachable directly from the property or through one shallow detail panel.

9.1 MVP Screens

Screen	Required content	Primary actions
Main Property View	Isometric boarding house, Cash, net income rate, Main Mission, event indicator, navigation.	Select room, open candidates, open mission, resolve event.
Room Detail	Room level, tenant, rent/day, net income/day, upgrade price, affordability status.	Upgrade room; inspect tenant.
Tenant Management	Candidate cards, archetype, maximum budget, suitable rooms, queue count.	Accept and assign; reject.
Event Dialog	Scenario, category, affected room/tenant, exact costs and outcomes.	Choose one deterministic response.



AI-generated screen-layout exploration only. Text inside this image is not authoritative; all functional labels and UI copy must follow the written GDD.

9.2 Interaction Rules

- Tapping a room opens Room Detail; tapping an empty slot opens the build action if capacity is unlocked.
- A room upgrade preview shows current rent, next rent, additional net income, upgrade cost, and estimated payback.
- Tenant cards show maximum budget and compatible vacant rooms.
- The Event Dialog presents both choices with costs and outcomes before confirmation.
- Main Mission progress remains visible from the Main Property View.

- Use confirmation prompts only for spending or decisions that cannot be reversed.

9.3 UX Guardrails

- Never hide a required action behind more than two navigation steps.
- Use readable labels and large tap targets for portrait mobile screens.
- Show disabled states with a concise reason (for example, “Need 2 occupied rooms”).
- Do not use red warning treatments for normal, non-urgent events.

10. Art Direction & Content Guidelines

ART DIRECTION — LOCKED

Friendly 2D isometric / 2.5D cartoon, bright but not childish, warm Vietnamese urban boarding-house details, clear room-level silhouettes, and expressive character reactions.

10.1 Visual Style

Area	Direction
Environment	Isometric or 2.5D view with readable floors, doors, windows, corridors, and room slots.
Characters	Stylized cartoon characters with strong silhouettes and readable expressions.
Palette	Warm neutrals for buildings, fresh greens, clear accent colors for interactive objects.
Room upgrades	Each level changes furniture and at least one prominent visual element.
Events	Short expressive illustrations or character portraits; reuse backgrounds when possible.
UI	Simple, high-contrast panels that do not obscure the property view.



Original vector-style environment concept created for this GDD. It is a direction reference, not a final game asset.



AI-generated character-style exploration; use only as inspiration for proportions and friendly expression.

10.2 Vietnamese Setting Details

- Motorbike parking, laundry lines, potted plants, utility meters, narrow corridors, shared water taps, and simple building signage.
- Keep details familiar and affectionate; avoid making any tenant archetype a negative stereotype.

10.3 Production Rules

- Use one consistent perspective, lighting direction, outline treatment, and palette across all production assets.
- Build a small reusable environment kit before producing many room variants.
- Create one final approved visual for each room level before expanding decorative variants.
- AI concept images in this document are not final assets and may contain inconsistent details or generated text.

11. MVP Scope & Non-Goals

11.1 In Scope

System	MVP requirement
Property	One boarding house with capacity progression from 2 to 4 to 6 rooms.
Rooms	Three room levels; construction and upgrades with visible changes.
Economy	Cash, rent, 10% operating cost, construction/upgrades, transparent investment values.
Offline	Eight-hour income cap; no offline events or candidates.
Tenants	Three archetypes, affordability matching, candidate queue, accept/reject.
Events	Four categories and five representative event templates.
Missions	One seven-step Main Mission chain and two progression milestones.

System	MVP requirement
Save	Full local state save/load and one-time offline calculation.
UI	Main Property, Room Detail, Tenant Management, Event Dialog.
Art	Consistent isometric/cartoon visual direction and visible room upgrades.

11.2 Explicitly Out of Scope

Feature	Reason for deferral
Multiple buildings / land plots	One property is enough to validate the core loop.
VIP and collectible tenants	Not needed to prove tenant matching or progression.
Satisfaction / relationship meters	Adds management burden before the event loop is proven.
Daily Missions / streaks	Retention layer to consider after playtesting.
Staff management / automation	Late-game systems; not required for MVP.
Multiple currencies / premium currency	No validated need in the MVP economy.
Complex lease, tax, debt, or accounting simulation	Conflicts with lightweight management direction.
Multiplayer, social systems, leaderboards	Not part of the single-player core experience.
Monetization / ads / IAP	Defer until the game loop and retention are validated.

11.3 Vertical Slice Recommendation

FIRST PLAYABLE TARGET

Build and validate the transition from 2 rooms to 4 rooms: rent accrual, tenant acceptance, one room upgrade, one new room, one event, one milestone, save/load, and offline income.

12. Acceptance Criteria & Playtest Plan

12.1 MVP Acceptance Criteria

- New players can understand the goal and identify the next Main Mission.
- Players can accept a compatible candidate into an empty room and cannot assign an unaffordable tenant.
- Room rent and operating cost update correctly for every occupied room and room level.
- Building and upgrading deduct the correct Cash amount and visibly update the property.
- An occupied room cannot be upgraded beyond the current tenant budget.
- Candidate generation follows the five-minute online interval, eligibility rules, spawn weights, and three-candidate cap.
- Events follow the online-only checks, cooldowns, frequency cap, eligibility rules, and deterministic outcomes.
- Main Mission progression and rewards trigger exactly once.
- Capacity and room-level unlocks occur at the specified milestones.
- Offline income respects the eight-hour cap and is credited once only.
- Closing and reopening the game restores rooms, tenants, candidates, events, missions, milestones, Cash, and timestamps.
- The main property view makes room growth and room-level upgrades visible.

12.2 Economy Playtest Questions

- Does the player understand when building a new room is better than upgrading an existing room?
- Do the 5.6–7.1 Game Day payback periods feel motivating at the one-hour-per-Game-Day time scale?

- Does the player reach the first capacity expansion without excessive waiting?
- Does the player have enough Cash to make meaningful decisions after handling an event?
- Does offline income feel rewarding without allowing the player to skip the entire progression curve?

12.3 Initial Telemetry (Recommended)

Metric	Why it matters
Time to accept second tenant	Checks onboarding clarity and candidate availability.
Time to first Level 2 upgrade	Checks early investment pacing.
Time to build Room 3 and Room 4	Checks build-cost balance.
Occupancy rate over time	Checks tenant supply versus room capacity.
Build-versus-upgrade selection rate	Checks whether both investment paths are viable.
Event trigger / resolution rate	Checks event frequency and friction.
Offline return interval and income received	Checks idle progression value.
Mission completion funnel	Finds progression bottlenecks.

12.4 Balance Change Policy

Use the values in this document as the first configuration. Do not tune numbers based on intuition alone. Adjust only after observing a repeatable bottleneck or dominant strategy in playtests. Keep economy values in configuration data rather than hard-coding them across gameplay logic.

13. Developer Configuration Reference

The following JSON is a readable starting configuration for implementation. Field names may be adapted to the codebase, but the values and semantics should remain equivalent.

```
{
  "time": {
    "real_minutes_per_game_day": 60,
    "offline_cap_hours": 8,
    "candidate_interval_online_minutes": 5
  },
  "economy": {
    "currency": "Cash",
    "operating_cost_rate": 0.1,
    "rent_accrual": "continuous_per_minute",
    "fractional_accrual": true
  },
  "rooms": {
    "max_rooms": 6,
    "initial_rooms": 2,
    "room_rent_per_game_day": {
      "1": 120,
      "2": 210,
      "3": 350
    },
    "build_cost_by_room_number": {
      "3": 900,
      "4": 1400,
      "5": 2100,
      "6": 3000
    },
    "upgrade_cost": {
      "1_to_2": 650,
      "2_to_3": 1300
    }
  },
  "progression": {
    "expansion_1": {
      "occupied_rooms": 2,
      "capacity": 4,
```

```
      "unlocks_room_level": 2
    },
    "expansion_2": {
      "occupied_rooms": 4,
      "level_2_rooms": 2,
      "capacity": 6,
      "unlocks_room_level": 3
    }
  },
  "tenants": {
    "queue_limit": 3,
    "weights": {
      "student": 0.5,
      "office_worker": 0.3,
      "messy_tenant": 0.2
    },
    "budget_per_game_day": {
      "student": 150,
      "office_worker": 380,
      "messy_tenant": 180
    }
  },
  "events": {
    "check_interval_online_minutes": 5,
    "base_trigger_chance": 0.25,
    "global_cooldown_online_minutes": 10,
    "per_event_cooldown_online_minutes": 30,
    "max_events_per_rolling_hour": 3,
    "max_active_events": 1,
    "max_combined_income_reduction": 0.25,
    "temporary_effects_continue_offline": true
  },
  "starting_state": {
    "cash": 1000,
    "occupied_rooms": 1,
    "vacant_rooms": 1,
    "initial_tenant": "office_worker",
    "initial_candidate": "student"
  }
}
```

13.1 Implementation Notes

- Use a single source of truth for room rent, costs, event effects, and progression thresholds.
- Represent temporary event modifiers with explicit start/end game-time values or remaining Game Days.
- Use integer Cash for UI, but maintain fractional rent accrual or a remainder field internally.
- Persist schema version and support future local-save migrations.
- Do not let UI labels or concept art override the written GDD values.

Appendix A. Key Definitions & Design Assumptions

Term	Definition
Game Day	One in-game day; equal to one real-time hour for rent accrual.
Gross Rent	Total rent generated by occupied rooms before operating cost.
Operating Cost	Automatic deduction equal to 10% of gross rent.
Net Income	Gross rent minus operating cost; 90% of gross rent.
Room Capacity	Maximum number of constructed room slots currently unlocked.
Occupancy	Number of constructed rooms with an assigned tenant.
Candidate	A tenant applicant waiting for player acceptance or rejection.
Eligible Candidate	A candidate whose budget can cover at least one vacant room.
Online Time	Time while the game is active; used for candidate and event checks.
Offline Time	Elapsed real time since the last active session, capped at eight hours for income.

Term	Definition
Balance Parameter	A numeric value that can be changed after playtesting without changing the underlying design rule.

A.1 Assumptions to Preserve

- The game is casual, single-player, and mobile-first.
- The property should continue to earn income while the player is away, but not accumulate more than eight hours of offline income.
- Events are optional interruptions that create clear choices; they are not an offline punishment system.
- The property and room upgrades must visually communicate progression.
- Any proposed feature that does not strengthen Earn → Manage → Invest → Grow → Unlock is deferred until after the MVP.

FINAL DESIGN DECISION

Build the 2-to-4-room vertical slice first. Validate the core economy, tenant matching, one or two event choices, visible room upgrades, save/load, and offline income before adding late-game systems.